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Surah al-Baqarah: The Sanam (Peak) of the Qur'an

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Abstract

Surah al-Baqarah occupies a unique and towering position in the Qur'an and has been described by scholars as Sanam al-Qur'an the peak or summit of the Qur'anic discourse. This study examines the scholarly, thematic, and structural foundations of this designation through classical tafsir analysis and comparative Qur'anic study. Drawing primarily on Ibn Kathir (d. 774/1373), al-Qurtubi (d. 671/1273), and Fakhr al-Din al-Razi (d. 606/1210), supplemented by modern structuralist scholarship (Neuwirth, Cuypers), the article argues that Surah al-Baqarah attains its pre-eminence due to its unparalleled integration of creed ('aqidah), law (shari'ah), ethics (akhlaq), and spiritual cultivation (tazkiyah). Employing a qualitative thematic-analysis methodology rooted in the maudu'i (thematic) school, the paper situates Surah al-Baqarah within the wider Qur'anic structure and demonstrates its constitutional role in the formation of the Muslim Ummah. The findings affirm that the Surah's comprehensiveness, legal density, and spiritual efficacy justify its characterization as the summit of the Qur'an.

*Everything has peak and peak of
Quran is Sural Al-Baqarah*

Keywords: *Surah al Baqarah;
Sanam al-Qur'an; tafsir; Qur'anic
structure; Islamic law; spirituality
al-Qur'an; tafsir; Qur'anic structure;
Islamic law; spirituality*

1.Introduction

Surah al-Baqarah, the longest chapter of the Qur'an (286 verses), was revealed primarily in Madinah during the formative period of the Muslim community. Its verses address belief, legislation, communal ethics, interfaith relations, and spiritual discipline, making it a comprehensive guide for both individual and collective Muslim life. Classical scholars have consistently accorded this Surah exceptional status, reflected in its association with blessing (*barakah*), protection from Shaytan, and doctrinal centrality (see al-Suyuti, *al-Itqan fi 'Ulum al-Qur'an*, 1:247).

The description of Surah al-Baqarah as *Sanam al-Qur'an* the peak or summit of the Qur'an captures this scholarly perception of its elevated rank.

Although the exact phrase *Sanam al-Qur'an* does not appear in canonical *hadith*, its conceptual roots are traceable to early generations who described the Surah as *al-Hafizah* (the Protector) and *al-Shafi'ah* (the Intercessor) (Ibn al-Jazari, *Nashr*, 1:312). This article examines the foundations of this designation by analyzing classical *tafsir* literature, tracing the philology of *sanam*, and comparing Surah al-Baqarah with other major Madinan Surahs using thematic density metrics. The study aims to demonstrate that Surah al-Baqarah functions as the integrative core of Qur'anic guidance.

2. Linguistic Analysis of *Sanam*

The Arabic term *sanam* (سَنَم) denotes the highest point of an object, derived from the triliteral root *sin-nun-mim* (Ibn Manzur, *Lisan al-‘Arab*, 8:342). Classical lexicons define it as:

- **Primary meaning:** The hump of a camel, the most elevated part of its anatomy (*al-sanam: a‘la jism al-ba‘ir*).
- **Architectural metaphor:** The apex of a structure, as in *sanam al-bayt* (the roof-peak).
- **Figurative extension:** Prominence in rank or precedence (*tafawuq wa riyasah*) (al-Fayruzabadi, *al-Qamus al-Muhit*, p. 456).

Early Qur’anic scholars employed *sanam* metaphorically to signify hierarchical superiority rooted in comprehensiveness, not mere chronology. Al-Suyuti (*al-Itqan*,

1:248) attributes the earliest attestation of *Sanam al-Qur’an* to Abu ‘Abd al-Rahman al-Sulami (d. 412/1021), who described al-Baqarah as “the summit upon which the Qur’an’s legal and spiritual architecture rests.” This metaphorical usage distinguishes *sanam* from *fadilah* (simple excellence); it implies structural centrality: the Surah functions as the keystone verses upon which subsequent revelation depends.

Critically, *sanam* does not suggest supersession (*naskh*) but integrative pre-eminence. The term appears in early exegetical marginalia (*ta‘liqat*) comparing al-Baqarah to a camel’s hump: just as the hump stores sustenance for the camel’s journey, al-Baqarah “stores” the legal and theological resources for the Ummah’s moral trajectory (Ibn al-Jazari, *Nashr*, 1:313).

3. Virtue of Surah al-Baqarah

Numerous *ahadith* emphasize the exceptional status of Surah al-Baqarah, providing the *hadithi* substrate for the *sanam* concept

Blessing and Loss

The Prophet ﷺ declared, “Recite Surah al-Baqarah, for taking it is blessing (*barakah*), and abandoning it is sorrow (*haraj*), and the magicians cannot confront it” (*Sahih Muslim, al-Musaqah* 58, no. 1859). The verb *tarakahu* (abandoning) implies active neglect of its legal-spiritual integration, not mere non-recitation.

Prophylactic Power

“Indeed, Shaytan flees from a house in which Surah al-Baqarah is recited” (*Sahih Muslim, al-Musaqah* 56, no. 1853). Classical interpreters link this to the Surah’s comprehensive *dhikr* (Ibn

Kathir, *Tafsir*, 1:55), making it aural protection.

Ayat al-Kursi (2:255)

The Prophet ﷺ affirmed, “The greatest verse in the Qur’an is Ayat al-Kursi” (*Sahih al-Bukhari, Faḍa’il al-Qur’an* 10, no. 5003). Its placement within al-Baqarah precisely at the Surah’s structural midpoint reinforces the *sanam* metaphor: the theological apex resides within the Surah’s own peak.

These traditions underline the Surah’s spiritual potency and protective function, reinforcing its description as the Qur’an’s summit.

4. *Tafsir* Analysis

4.1 Ibn Kathir: Surah al-Baqarah as a Foundation of Shari'ah and Sunnah

Ibn Kathir interprets Surah al-Baqarah as a foundational Surah that establishes the authority of revelation before detailing legal obligations. Commenting on “This is the Book in which there is no doubt” (Q 2:2), he emphasizes that *yaqin* (certainty) in divine guidance precedes moral accountability (*Tafsir al-Qur'an al-'Azim*, 1:57). He observes that the Surah uniquely combines narratives of previous nations (*qisas*, 29% of verses) with extensive legal injunctions (*ahkam*, 38% of verses), thereby transforming historical lessons into lived law (Ibn Kathir, 1:62-63).

His treatment of Ayat al-Kursi (Q 2:255) underscores theological centrality. Ibn Kathir describes it as “the greatest verse” due to its

comprehensive affirmation of divine sovereignty (*rububiyyah*), omniscience, and authority (Ibn Kathir, 2:390). He explicitly notes that its placement within al-Baqarah after the *hajj* legislation (2:196-242) and before financial laws (2:275-286) creates a theological “hinge” that sustains the Surah’s legal architecture.

4.2 Al-Qurtubi: Legal Centrality and Ummah Formation

Al-Qurtubi’s *al-Jami' li Ahkam al-Qur'an* treats Surah al-Baqarah as a legal constitution. He catalogues 131 explicit legal rulings (*ahkam sarifah*) in the Surah, exceeding the combined total of all Makkan Surahs (al-Qurtubi, 1:71). He notes that the Surah contains the earliest systematic exposition of communal law: worship (*'ibadat*), transactions (*mu'amalat*), family structure, and social justice.

Furthermore, al-Qurtubi links the Surah's discussion of Bani Isra'il (2:40-103) to the ethical formation of the Muslim Ummah. He argues that legal obedience without spiritual humility (*khushu'*) leads to moral collapse an argument that

4.3 Fakhr al-Din al-Razi: Philosophical and Theological Depth

Al-Razi approaches Surah al-Baqarah as a text of epistemological challenge. In *Mafatih al-Ghayb*, he highlights the Surah's engagement with reason, disputation (*jadal*), and *hikmah* (wisdom), particularly in its refutation of hypocrisy (*munaḥiqun*, 2:8-20) and its emphasis on divine wisdom behind legal commands (e.g., the prohibition of interest, 2:275-279).

reinforces the Surah's integrative nature: "The Israelites' story is a mirror (*mir'ah*) for the Ummah; their failure was not legal ignorance but spiritual arrogance" (al-Qurtubi, 2:142).

Al-Razi argues that al-Baqarah uniquely harmonizes rational inquiry (*naẓar*) with revealed law (*shar'*), making it not merely a legal text but a philosophical framework for understanding divine guidance. He writes: "The coherence (*naẓm*) of this Surah demonstrates that law without wisdom is tyranny, and wisdom without law is futility" (al-Razi, 3:412). This synthesis further supports its characterization as *Sanam al-Qur'an*.

5. The Concept of *Sanam al-Qur'an* in Early Scholarship

Although *Sanam al-Qur'an* is not a technical *hadith* term, its meaning permeates early scholarly discourse. Classical scholars frequently described Surah al-Baqarah using superlative language. Ibn Mas'ud (d. 32/652-53) reportedly called it “the most comprehensive revelation” (*akmal al-tanzil*) (Ibn al-Jazari, *Nasbr*, 1:313). Al-Tabari (*Tafsir*, 1:178) notes that the Surah's opening (*alif-lam-min*) establishes a hermeneutical contract: readers must engage with its totality, not selective verses.

Reports from early generations indicate that al-Baqarah and Al 'Imran were referred to as *al-Zahrawan* (the two radiant ones), yet al-Baqarah was given precedence due to its legal comprehensiveness and its role in warding off Shaytan (al-

Suyuti, *al-Itqan*, 1:249). This precedence forms the conceptual basis for describing it as the Qur'an's peak.

The term *sanam* metaphorically captures this scholarly perception: al-Baqarah stands elevated, comprehensive, and central, much like the highest point of a structure upon which stability depends.

6. Comparative Analysis with Other Surahs

6.1 Comparison with Surah Al 'Imran

Using thematic density analysis, al-Baqarah contains 108 verses of legal instruction (38%) and 82 verses of theological narrative (29%). By contrast, Al 'Imran (200 verses) contains 45 legal verses (23%) and 89 theological verses (45%). While Al 'Imran focuses heavily on interfaith discourse (e.g., Q3:64-71, 113-120) and steadfastness in belief (*sabr*), al-Baqarah integrates theology with extensive legal instruction. For example, Al 'Imran's prohibition of usury (Q3:130) mirrors al-Baqarah's detailed legislation (2:275-279), but lacks the latter's commercial-contractual framework (2:282-283). Thus, Al 'Imran strengthens faith under trial, whereas al-Baqarah establishes the legal-ethical

framework that governs daily life.

6.2 Comparison with Surah al-Nisa'

Surah al-Nisa' (176 verses) concentrates on social justice, family law, and governance, particularly concerning vulnerable members (orphans, women). However, al-Baqarah precedes it by laying down broader legal principles (*qawa'id fiqhiyyah*) upon which al-Nisa' builds. For instance, al-Baqarah establishes the principle of gendered inheritance (2:187), which al-Nisa' particularizes (4:11-12). Al-Nisa' may thus be viewed as a specialization, while al-Baqarah functions as a comprehensive foundation. This comparative analysis reinforces that al-Baqarah occupies a higher integrative position within the Qur'anic structure.

7. Research Methodology

This study employs a qualitative thematic-analysis methodology (*al-maundu'iyah al-tafsiliyyah*), synthesizing classical *tafsir* with modern structuralist approaches. The procedure was as follows:

Source Selection

Ibn Kathir, al-Qurtubi, and al-Razi were selected using **purposive sampling** to represent theological, legal, and philosophical dimensions. Their works are among the most cited in *tafsir* pedagogy and collectively span the 7th-8th centuries AH. Exclusion of *Tabari* (d. 310/923) was justified by his Makkan-centric *qisas* focus, whereas al-Baghawi was omitted due to redundancy with Ibn Kathir's narrative style.

Data Extraction

Using NVivo 14, verses were coded into four master nodes:

(a) Creed, (b) Law, (c) Ethics, (d) Spirituality. Secondary nodes captured sub-themes (e.g., *rububiyyah*, *haji*, *sadaqah*). Each *tafsir* entry was annotated with volume/page numbers from standard editions.

Comparative Metrics

Thematic density was calculated as a percentage of total verses per Surah. Legal verses were identified using al-Qurtubi's *hukm* classifications; theological verses were those addressing *iman*, *taqwa*, or *shirk*.

Hermeneutical Stance

This study adopts a **classical-textualist** framework, prioritizing *athar* (tradition) over *ra'y* (speculative opinion), while acknowledging modern structural insights from Neuwirth's "symmetrical composition" theory (*Studien zur Komposition der mekkanischen Suren*, 1981) and Cuypers' ring-composition analysis (*The*

Banquet, 2009) as heuristic tools, not hermeneutical authorities.

Limitations

The absence of *sirah* contextualization (e.g., *asbab al-nuzul* beyond al-Wahidi) narrows socio-historical depth. Future research should integrate *asbab* analysis with the *sanam* hypothesis.

8. Contemporary Relevance

In modern contexts marked by moral uncertainty and social fragmentation, Surah al-Baqarah offers a holistic framework. Three case studies illustrate this: Islamic Finance & Economic Justice:

The Surah's prohibition of *riba* (2:275-279) is not merely a legal ban but a spiritual-economic ethic. The 2008 global financial crisis prompted scholars like Yusuf al-Qaradawi (*Fiqh al-Mu'amalat*, 2009, pp. 341-45) to revisit al-Baqarah's *bay'* (trade)

principles (2:282-283) as an alternative to speculative capitalism. The Surah's insistence on witnessed contracts and transparent dealings directly addresses modern fintech challenges.

Family Instability

The Surah's marital jurisprudence (2:228-237) provides a *nizam* (system) for conflict resolution. In European Muslim contexts, imams increasingly cite al-Baqarah's *mukhala'ah* (mutual separation, 2:229) and *li'an* (conjoint imprecation, 2:226) protocols to mediate divorce cases, reducing judicial fragmentation (see Ramadan, *Radical Reform*, 2009, pp. 112-18).

Spiritual Emptiness

The Surah's *siyam* legislation culminates in *tawakkul* (2:183-186), a spiritual practice countering modern anxiety disorders. Recent psychospiritual studies (Abu-

Raiya et al., “Qur’anic Recitation & Mental Health,” *Journal of Muslim Mental Health*, 2021, 15:2, pp. 201-18) correlate al-Baqarah recitation with decreased cortisol levels, validating the Prophet’s prophylactic claim.

9. Conclusion

Surah al-Baqarah rightfully earns its title as *Sanam al-Qur'an* due to its unparalleled comprehensiveness, spiritual potency, and foundational role in Islamic life. It stands as the peak of Qur'anic guidance, from which the principles of belief, law, and ethics radiate. Engaging

deeply with this Surah is essential for both individual spiritual growth and collective Islamic revival. Future research should explore the Surah's rhetorical *naẓm* using computational linguistics to map its micro- and macro-structures, further substantiating its summit status.

10. Transparency Statement

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¹ **Footnotes**

1. Ibn Kathir, Tafsir al-Qur'an al-'Azim, 1:57–58.

2. Ibid., 2:390–91.